

Customers have never had it this good as banks go all out to woo them. A look at what Indian banks have on offer...

Banking on technology

Pop in your ATM card and it takes less than five seconds for the bank's computers to respond to your request, but Yudhishtir Chede isn't really thinking of that as he checks his account and withdraws cash. If you bank with HDFC, for instance, all the ATM, Internet and phone banking queries that you make worldwide are routed through the core customer-banking database in suburban Mumbai. In fact, with many Indian banks today, it doesn't matter where you are, or how you choose to connect—you always get service, anytime, and just about everywhere. Welcome to banking in the new millennium; the customer is king here!

Banking has moved a long way from the 19th century. However, the kind of services that we customers have come to take for granted have been a recent phenomenon as private and public sector banks go all out to woo customers with quality services. Even a decade ago, you'd be standing in a queue and waiting for service; today, you conduct transactions in seconds at the press of a button or the click of a mouse.

Computerisation is working

"Automation has come forth as a by-product of business requirements," says V Chandrasekhar, CTO, Bank of Baroda

(BoB), one of India's largest public sector banks.

His bank has an enviable record, having been recognised internationally for its remote banking services. Microbanker Online magazine awarded BoB the Best in Remote Banking award in 2001. As a matter of fact, banking operations today aren't different from those at cutting edge network operations centres.

At HDFC, for instance, bankers manning the operations at their worldwide data centre are technologists to the core. They monitor the centralised banking database, the core



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